

I am planning to create music for focusing on tasks. Please list out some requirements and characteristics of such music, and use it to create a prompt for an AI music generation software.



Characteristics of Effective Focus Music

Focus music is not just “calm music.” It is designed to minimize cognitive interference while maintaining enough stimulation to prevent boredom. The main goal is sustained attention.

1. Predictability

- Repetitive structures help the brain stop actively tracking the music.
- Avoid sudden transitions, key changes, or dramatic drops.
- Use looping motifs and gradual evolution.

2. Low Linguistic Load

- Lyrics compete with verbal working memory.
- Instrumental music is usually better for studying, coding, reading, and writing.
- If vocals exist, they should be:
 - wordless
 - heavily processed
 - distant in the mix

3. Moderate Complexity

Too simple:

- becomes mentally fatiguing through monotony.

Too complex:

- captures attention.

Good focus music sits in the middle:

- layered but unobtrusive

- subtle rhythmic movement
- controlled harmonic progression

4. Stable Tempo

- Usually between **60–90 BPM**.
- Consistent rhythm helps maintain mental pacing.
- Excessive syncopation or aggressive percussion is distracting.

5. Smooth Frequency Balance

- Harsh highs and muddy bass reduce long-session comfort.
- Common traits:
 - soft highs
 - warm mids
 - controlled low-end
 - minimal transient spikes

6. Long Dynamic Curves

- Avoid abrupt loudness jumps.
- Compression and smooth automation are useful.
- Energy should rise and fall gradually over minutes.

7. Minimal Attention Hooks

Avoid:

- catchy vocal melodies
- highly memorable riffs
- virtuosic solos
- comedic or emotionally charged elements

The listener should not feel compelled to “actively listen.”

Common Genres Used for Focus

Ambient

- Slow evolving pads
- Sparse melodies

- Atmospheric textures

Examples:

- Brian Eno
- Music for Airports

Lo-fi Hip Hop

- Soft beats
- Vinyl texture
- Jazz-inspired harmony
- Relaxed rhythmic groove

Minimal Electronic

- Repetitive pulse
- Controlled synthesis
- Low emotional volatility

Neo-Classical Minimalism

- Repeating piano motifs
- Light strings
- Slow harmonic movement

Examples:

- Max Richter
- Ludovico Einaudi

Nature + Ambient Hybrids

- Rain
- Café ambience
- Brown noise
- Forest atmospheres

Technical Recommendations

Element	Recommended Range
BPM	60–90
Time Signature	4/4
Track Length	15–60 min
Loudness	Consistent, non-aggressive
Key	Minor or modal often works well
Percussion	Soft/transient-controlled
Arrangement	Gradual evolution

AI Music Generation Prompt

General Focus Music Prompt

Create a long-form instrumental focus track designed for deep work, studying, programming, and reading.

Style: ambient minimal electronic with subtle lo-fi textures.

Tempo: 72 BPM.

Use soft evolving pads, warm analog synths, gentle piano motifs, restrained percussion, and light atmospheric textures.

The composition should be repetitive but slowly evolving, emotionally neutral, calming without becoming sleepy, and immersive without demanding attention.

Avoid vocals, sharp transients, dramatic transitions, virtuosic solos, sudden drops, or catchy melodic hooks.

Maintain stable dynamics and smooth frequency balance suitable for long listening sessions with headphones.

Include subtle tape hiss, soft reverb, and low-volume environmental ambience for depth.

Structure the piece to evolve gradually over 20–40 minutes with seamless looping capability.

Variant Prompts

Coding / Deep Concentration

Dark ambient minimal techno for sustained concentration, precise rhythmic pulse, soft sub-bass, sparse synth arpeggios, emotionally restrained atmosphere, highly repetitive structure, 75 BPM, no vocals, no dramatic changes.

Reading / Writing

Soft neo-classical ambient focus music with felt piano, warm strings, subtle room ambience, slow harmonic motion, emotionally neutral tone, minimal percussion, highly non-distracting.

Mathematics / Analytical Work

Clean minimal electronic focus soundtrack with gentle polyrhythms, subdued pulses, low harmonic density, smooth synth textures, cognitive clarity, controlled repetition, 70 BPM.

Relaxed Study Session

Lo-fi ambient study beat with jazz chords, vinyl crackle, muted drums, warm bass, rain ambience, soft keys, calm nighttime atmosphere, repetitive and non-intrusive.

One Important Design Principle

The best focus music is usually *less emotionally expressive* than ordinary music.

Many people accidentally generate tracks that are:

- too cinematic
- too melodic
- too emotional
- too rhythmically exciting

Those work for listening. They often fail for concentration.

Your target is functional immersion, not active entertainment.

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You Asked



create different versions of the prompt for creating working music in different working contexts. Further more, the music should not be completely relaxing, but have some underlying tension within the music. For example, add some short techno beats such as the ones within the soundtrack "Stranded on Europa". However, it is important to not overdo it to avoid distraction.

The key idea here is **controlled momentum**.

Pure relaxation music often causes:

- mental drift
- drowsiness
- reduced task urgency

But excessively energetic music causes:

- attentional fragmentation
- compulsive listening
- cognitive overload

What you want is a balance:

- calm surface
- restrained propulsion underneath

That “underlying tension” is extremely effective for:

- programming
- problem solving
- design work
- long study sessions
- deadline-driven tasks

The soundtrack from Stranded on Europa uses this principle well:

- sparse but persistent pulse
- low-level rhythmic urgency
- mechanical atmosphere
- subtle tension without climax overload

Below are optimized prompt variants for different cognitive states.

1. Deep Programming / Systems Thinking

Best for:

- coding

- debugging
- engineering
- mathematical work
- long analytical sessions

Characteristics

- restrained techno pulse
- mechanical precision
- dark ambient undertones
- subtle tension
- minimal melodic content
- hypnotic repetition

Prompt

Create an instrumental deep-focus electronic track for programming and systems thinking.

Style: ambient techno with minimal cinematic elements.

Tempo: 74 BPM.

Use soft pulsing techno percussion, muted kick drums, low analog bass, restrained synth arpeggios, distant atmospheric pads, and subtle mechanical textures.

The music should maintain a persistent feeling of forward motion and low-level urgency without becoming aggressive or distracting.

Include short rhythmic motifs inspired by intelligent minimal techno and space-survival atmospheres similar to “Stranded on Europa,” but keep all beats subdued and tightly controlled in the mix.

Avoid catchy melodies, vocals, dramatic drops, bright leads, excessive percussion fills, or emotional crescendos.

The track should feel focused, cold, futuristic, and immersive — like maintaining concentration inside a quiet spacecraft system.

Long-form structure with gradual evolution over 30+ minutes.

2. Deadline / Productive Pressure Music

Best for:

- finishing assignments

- crunch sessions
- late-night productivity
- maintaining urgency

Characteristics

- stronger pulse
- mild anxiety/tension
- repetitive drive
- controlled intensity

Prompt

Create focused productivity music with subtle psychological tension and restrained techno energy.

Style: minimal dark electronic with ambient textures.

Tempo: 82 BPM.

Use short percussive techno pulses, soft industrial textures, low drones, muted rhythmic synths, and repeating motifs that create momentum without overpowering concentration.

The emotional tone should suggest quiet urgency and disciplined focus rather than relaxation.

Keep the arrangement highly repetitive and stable, with small evolving details over time.

Avoid dramatic transitions, loud snares, emotional melodies, festival-style EDM elements, or anything euphoric.

The music should support sustained productivity during mentally demanding work sessions while maintaining subtle internal pressure.

3. Reading / Writing Concentration

Best for:

- essay writing
- reading
- research
- language-heavy tasks

Characteristics

- lighter rhythmic density

- softer tension
- minimal interference with verbal processing

Prompt

Create instrumental focus music for reading and writing with subtle underlying tension.

Style: ambient neo-classical mixed with restrained minimal electronic textures.

Tempo: 68 BPM.

Use soft felt piano, distant synth pads, sparse low percussion, gentle ticking pulses, warm drones, and subtle repeating rhythmic patterns.

Add a quiet sense of anticipation and momentum beneath the calm atmosphere, avoiding complete relaxation or sleepiness.

Rhythmic elements should be minimal but present enough to sustain concentration and mental pacing.

Avoid vocals, strong melodic hooks, emotional piano solos, dramatic chord progressions, or cinematic swells.

The track should feel intellectually focused, introspective, and slightly tense in a productive way.

4. Scientific / Mathematical Work

Best for:

- proofs
- physics
- algorithm design
- abstract reasoning

Characteristics

- precision
- pattern consistency
- low emotionality
- subtle rhythmic structure

Prompt

Create highly controlled instrumental focus music for mathematics and scientific reasoning.

Style: minimal ambient techno with clean synthetic textures.

Tempo: 72 BPM.

Use precise soft percussion, repeating pulse patterns, restrained modular synth sequences, smooth drones, and subtle evolving textures.

The music should feel analytical, structured, and cognitively sharpening rather than emotionally expressive.

Add low-level tension through repeating rhythmic fragments and controlled harmonic dissonance, while keeping the overall sound unobtrusive.

Avoid lyrical vocals, expressive solos, cinematic drama, or overly emotional harmonies.

The atmosphere should resemble sustained concentration inside a futuristic research environment.

5. Creative Flow / Design Work

Best for:

- drawing
- UI/UX
- visual design
- brainstorming
- creative coding

Characteristics

- slightly more texture
- more emotional openness
- still disciplined

Prompt

Create atmospheric focus music for creative flow and design work.

Style: ambient electronic with restrained techno influences and subtle cinematic textures.

Tempo: 78 BPM.

Use warm synth layers, soft rhythmic pulses, light glitch textures, distant percussion, and evolving ambient atmospheres.

The music should balance calm immersion with subtle forward-driving tension to maintain engagement during long creative sessions.

Rhythms should be understated and hypnotic rather than energetic.

Avoid overly catchy melodies, emotional climaxes, aggressive drums, or dense arrangements.

The emotional tone should feel futuristic, thoughtful, slightly tense, and creatively stimulating.

Additional Techniques to Mention in Prompts

These phrases often improve AI-generated focus music quality:

Useful Additions

- “slow evolving textures”
- “restrained rhythmic propulsion”
- “controlled harmonic dissonance”
- “subtle unresolved atmosphere”
- “non-cinematic tension”
- “minimal transient spikes”
- “steady cognitive pacing”
- “functional immersion”
- “emotionally restrained”
- “hypnotic repetition”
- “micro-variation over repetition”

Things to Explicitly Avoid

- “epic”
- “cinematic trailer”
- “uplifting”
- “emotional climax”
- “virtuosic”
- “anthemic”
- “festival energy”
- “melodic lead focus”
- “aggressive EDM”
- “dramatic orchestration”

Those terms frequently derail focus-oriented generation.

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When I plugged in the prompts to the AI, the AI returned music that uses half-notes as beats, so the effective BPM is twice the value specified. REwrite the prompt to avoid this. Furthermore, emphasize the "slow-paced" characteristic of the music to ensure that the pace is slower for the music.

 ChatGPT gpt-5-5

The issue is that many music-generation models interpret BPM ambiguously:

- they may treat the pulse as half-time
- use sparse percussion that psychologically halves the tempo
- or generate cinematic pacing despite the numerical BPM

So instead of only specifying BPM, explicitly define:

- the perceived pulse
- note density
- rhythmic subdivision
- pacing language
- spacing between percussion hits

You want:

- slow-paced
- restrained
- deliberate
- pulse-driven
- but still subtly propulsive

Below is a rewritten framework optimized to prevent accidental "double-speed perception."

Core Tempo Instructions to Add

Add phrases like:

- The perceived pulse should feel slow and deliberate, not energetic or driving.
- Use sparse quarter-note rhythmic pacing rather than fast eighth-note momentum.
- Percussion should be widely spaced with substantial negative space between hits.
- Avoid half-time ambiguity that makes the track feel faster than the intended tempo.
- Rhythms should feel heavy, slow-moving, and grounded.
- Emphasize sustained tones and long atmospheric decay over rhythmic density.
- The listener should perceive a slow continuous crawl rather than forward sprinting momentum.

These phrases matter more than raw BPM numbers.

Rewritten Prompt — Deep Programming / Analytical Work

Create slow-paced instrumental focus music for deep programming and analytical work.

Style: ambient minimal techno with restrained futuristic atmosphere.

True perceived tempo: slow and deliberate at approximately 70 BPM quarter-note pulse.

The music must feel genuinely slow-moving rather than half-time electronic music that psychologically feels twice as fast.

Use sparse percussion with large gaps between hits, restrained kick drums, subtle low-frequency pulses, distant mechanical textures, warm drones, and slowly evolving synth layers.

Rhythmic motion should be minimal, controlled, and hypnotic.

Emphasize sustained atmosphere and gradual evolution over rhythmic activity.

Add subtle underlying tension through quiet techno-inspired pulse fragments similar to the restrained rhythmic elements in “Stranded on Europa,” but keep them deeply buried in the mix and non-distracting.

Avoid energetic sequencing, rapid hi-hats, fast arpeggios, dense percussion, syncopated rhythmic complexity, EDM-style momentum, or cinematic action pacing.

The track should feel like slow mechanical movement inside a massive spacecraft or research facility — calm, focused, slightly tense, but never hurried.

Maintain emotional restraint, low melodic density, and extremely smooth transitions over long-form development.

Rewritten Prompt — Deadline Productivity

This version keeps urgency while remaining slow.

Create slow-paced productivity music with subtle internal tension and restrained techno influence.

Style: dark ambient electronic minimalism.

Perceived tempo should remain slow, heavy, and deliberate at roughly 76 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Avoid rhythmic patterns that create the psychological impression of double tempo or fast pacing.

Use muted percussion, low industrial textures, restrained pulse sequences, soft analog bass movement, and sparse repeating motifs.

The music should create quiet disciplined urgency without excitement or adrenaline.

Rhythms should be sparse and carefully spaced, with significant atmospheric breathing room between percussive events.

Keep all transitions gradual and understated.

Avoid bright hi-hats, rapid rhythmic subdivisions, melodic hooks, aggressive basslines, cinematic impacts, or energetic techno drive.

The atmosphere should feel like controlled late-night concentration under pressure rather than intense action or stimulation.

Rewritten Prompt — Reading / Writing

Create extremely slow-paced instrumental focus music for reading and writing concentration.

Style: ambient neo-classical blended with restrained electronic textures.

Use a slow perceived pulse around 64 BPM with minimal rhythmic density.

Emphasize long sustained tones, soft piano resonance, distant drones, subtle ticking pulses, and sparse low percussion.

The pacing should feel patient, spacious, and mentally stabilizing.

Add subtle unresolved tension underneath the calm atmosphere through faint low-frequency rhythmic fragments and restrained harmonic ambiguity.

Avoid emotional piano melodies, strong rhythmic drive, fast subdivisions, bright percussion, dramatic crescendos, or cinematic sentimentality.

The music should feel intellectually focused and quietly tense while remaining genuinely slow-moving and non-distracting.

Additional Prompt Phrases That Help

To Slow the Music Down

Add:

- “wide rhythmic spacing”
- “large amounts of negative space”
- “minimal note density”
- “slow-moving pulse”
- “heavy pacing”
- “long sustained textures”
- “avoid constant rhythmic motion”
- “restrained quarter-note pulse”
- “slow atmospheric crawl”
- “very gradual evolution”

To Prevent Accidental Energy

Explicitly ban:

- rapid hi-hats
 - rolling percussion
 - constant arpeggiation
 - rhythmic layering
 - driving basslines
 - trance momentum
 - syncopated percussion
 - energetic subdivisions
 - rhythmic complexity
-

Important Observation

A lot of AI music systems are biased toward:

- cinematic pacing
- trailer music structure
- EDM momentum
- overstimulation

So successful prompts often spend more text explaining:

- what to avoid than:
- what to include

That negative guidance is usually what produces usable focus music.

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For the programming context, let the prompt reflect this scenario: a programmer is sitting down in front of his computer with a cup of coffee, getting comfortable to code and create something important. Think of Iron Man when he is designing a suit.

For the deadline context, imagine a team of students working in flow state with the deadline looming. However, they are not frantically finishing things but coordinating their work so that they finish in time. The atmosphere should be calm with a slight whiff of tension.

For the reading context, imagine sitting at a coffee shop on a beanbag and reading your favorite book with hot chocolate beside you. A jazz band is playing some blues. (put some saxophone in the music)

For the scientific and mathematical work, imagine someone working on a blackboard to discover the secrets of the cosmos. Think of scenes from Interstellar or Oppenheimer.

For the creative flow and design work, think of a group of people sitting down at a wooden meeting room with warm lighting, each having a cup of coffee, and discussing solutions for a design.

Some universal changes: lower the volume of the percussion by muffling it. Furthermore, in the prompt, include statements that

directly tell the music generation AI what elements and instruments to include, and not what mood the music should create



1. Programming / Engineering / Building Something Important

Scenario reference: A programmer sits down late at night with coffee beside the keyboard, opening an IDE to build something meaningful. Think of technical design scenes from Iron Man where systems are being engineered and refined.

Prompt

Create slow-paced instrumental focus music for programming and engineering work.

Use ambient minimal techno with restrained futuristic electronic production.

Tempo should feel genuinely slow and deliberate at approximately 70 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Include:

- warm analog synth pads
- low sustained bass drones
- muted techno kick drums with heavy muffling
- sparse low-volume percussion
- subtle mechanical clicking textures
- restrained synth pulses
- distant electronic ambience
- soft filtered arpeggiator fragments
- tape hiss and room ambience

Percussion must remain deeply buried in the mix with soft attack and minimal high frequencies.

Rhythmic spacing should be wide with substantial negative space between hits.

Use slow harmonic movement and gradual layering over time.

Keep melodic content minimal and repetitive.

Avoid fast hi-hats, aggressive basslines, EDM energy, cinematic trailer drums, emotional orchestral swells, rapid sequencing, or bright lead synths.

The arrangement should resemble someone calmly engineering advanced technology late at night while fully concentrated on building a complex system.

2. Deadline / Coordinated Team Workflow

Scenario reference: A team of students works together late into the night before a deadline. Everyone is focused and coordinated rather than panicked. Papers, laptops, coffee cups, and quiet discussion fill the room.

Prompt

Create slow-paced productivity music with restrained tension and controlled momentum.

Use minimal ambient electronic instrumentation with soft techno influences.

Tempo should feel slow and grounded at approximately 76 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Include:

- muted kick drums
- soft low percussion
- warm bass pulses
- subtle industrial textures
- restrained synth ostinatos
- soft analog pads
- quiet ticking percussion
- low atmospheric drones
- lightly filtered electronic textures

Percussion should be heavily muffled, low-volume, and placed deep in the background.

Use repeating rhythmic fragments with wide spacing and minimal rhythmic density.

Add gradual textural evolution instead of dramatic transitions.

Avoid frantic pacing, rapid percussion, aggressive techno sequencing, emotional climaxes, bright cymbals, EDM drops, or cinematic action music structure.

The arrangement should resemble a calm, organized late-night workflow where multiple people are coordinating efficiently under time pressure.

3. Reading / Coffee Shop / Jazz Blues

Scenario reference: Someone is sitting on a beanbag inside a warm coffee shop reading a favorite book with hot chocolate nearby while a jazz band quietly plays blues in the background.

Prompt

Create slow-paced instrumental focus music for reading in a warm coffee shop environment.

Blend ambient jazz, soft blues, and restrained lo-fi production.

Tempo should feel relaxed and spacious at approximately 62 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Include:

- soft tenor saxophone phrases
- brushed jazz drums with heavy muffling
- upright bass played sparsely
- warm electric piano chords
- soft Rhodes piano
- subtle vinyl crackle
- low café ambience
- gentle room reverb
- quiet sustained ambient pads

Saxophone phrases should be slow, sparse, and understated rather than virtuosic or emotionally overpowering.

Percussion should remain quiet, soft, and deeply blended into the mix.

Use minimal note density and long pauses between melodic phrases.

Avoid energetic jazz solos, fast swing rhythms, bright brass sections, strong rhythmic drive, emotional crescendos, or complex improvisation.

The arrangement should resemble a quiet jazz band softly performing in the corner of a café while someone reads comfortably for hours.

4. Scientific / Mathematical Discovery

Scenario reference: Someone works alone at a blackboard searching for a breakthrough in physics or mathematics. Think of scientific discovery scenes from *Interstellar* or *Oppenheimer*.

Prompt

Create slow-paced instrumental music for scientific and mathematical work.

Use ambient orchestral-electronic hybrid instrumentation with restrained minimal techno influence.

Tempo should feel slow, heavy, and deliberate at approximately 68 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Include:

- deep sustained string drones
- soft low piano notes
- restrained analog synth textures
- subtle pulsing bass tones
- distant orchestral ambience
- low filtered percussion
- sparse mechanical rhythmic pulses
- soft granular textures
- minimal brass swells at extremely low volume

Percussion should remain heavily muffled and secondary to the atmospheric layers.

Use slow harmonic progression and gradual accumulation of texture over long time spans.

Keep melodies minimal and unresolved.

Avoid action-movie percussion, dramatic cinematic impacts, heroic themes, rapid rhythmic development, emotional orchestration, or dense musical layering.

The arrangement should resemble quiet scientific problem-solving on a blackboard late at night while working toward a major theoretical discovery.

5. Creative Flow / Design Collaboration

Scenario reference: A group of designers and engineers sits together around a wooden meeting table with warm lighting and coffee cups, discussing ideas and sketching solutions.

Prompt

Create slow-paced instrumental focus music for collaborative design and creative problem-solving sessions.

Use warm ambient electronic production with restrained organic textures.

Tempo should feel slow and steady at approximately 72 BPM quarter-note pulse.

Include:

- warm synth pads
- soft plucked electronic textures
- muted low percussion
- brushed rhythmic elements
- subtle bass pulses
- soft electric piano chords
- restrained guitar ambience
- low vinyl texture
- gentle room ambience
- sparse electronic pulse fragments

Percussion should be muffled, soft, and minimally intrusive.

Use gradual evolution with repeating textures and slow pacing.

Keep melodic phrases short and understated.

Avoid aggressive electronic production, bright lead synths, energetic rhythmic motion, cinematic emotional swells, fast percussion, or dense arrangement changes.

The arrangement should resemble a warm late-night creative meeting where people are calmly discussing and refining ideas over coffee.

Universal Production Additions

You can append these to nearly every prompt:

Use low dynamic contrast and smooth compression.

Keep percussion low-volume, muffled, and filtered to reduce distraction.

Emphasize sustained textures over rhythmic density.

Maintain slow pacing with wide rhythmic spacing and substantial negative space.

Use gradual layering and slow atmospheric evolution over long durations.

Avoid sudden transitions, fast subdivisions, bright transients, or attention-grabbing melodic hooks.